

The Metropolitan Digest

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2026-03-30

FRONT PAGE

‘A kaleidoscope of colour and life’: readers’ favourite UK spring days out

Guardian readers · The Guardian Travel

Your top tips for seasonal outings from birdwatching to gorgeous gardens, amazing architecture and more • Tell us about a trip to Spain – the best tip wins a £200 holiday voucher

Last April, I based myself in Oban and took my teenagers puffin-watching at Lunga, off Mull, in the Treshnish Isles, with an organised tour (Staffa Tours) by ferry and foot. It was a real delight. The guides were brilliant and helpful, especially with my mobility issues, and we were surprised and amazed at how tame and friendly the puffins were – allowing us to get great views of their faces from as near as 5ft or so. Next spring, we are going again as this is the best time to see them arriving in their thousands. April

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FEATURES

The Amex Platinum Card: Why It's Worth it

Kristin Addis · Be My Travel Muse

Right now, they're offering a targeted welcome offer of up to 175,000 miles when you follow a referral link, which you can access [here!](#)

The American Express Platinum Card, often heralded as the epitome of luxury in the credit card world, comes with a hefty annual fee of \$895. This fee may seem huge, but for those who can leverage the card's extensive benefits, it more than pays for itself. There's a reason why I've held onto mine for five years and will continue to hold onto it for the future.

In this review, I'll dive deep into the perks that make the Amex Platinum Card a mainstay in my wallet, despite its cost. We'll also touch on the downsides, including the increasing crowding in airport lounges and the recent limitations on guest access.

(Some users report opening in different apps helps if at first you don't receive the offer).

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Benefits That Offset the Annual Fee

Using my resort credit at the 5-star Prince Gallery Kioicho in Tokyo

Currently the welcome offer is up to 175k through this referral link , which can go a long, long way. These points can be worth up to \$800 or more, depending on how they're redeemed.

For example, I flew in Singapore Airlines business class (how I find deals) all the way from San Francisco to Bali for 107,000 miles, so the welcome offer got me much of the way there. Here's how to make the card perks make sense.

✈️ Travel Credits & Travel-Related Perks

\$200 Airline Fee Credit

Select one airline each calendar year and receive up to \$200 in statement credits for eligible incidental charges (e.g., baggage fees, seat assignments, in-flight food/drinks).

\$600 Hotel Credit

Get up to \$300 in statement credits semi-annually (total \$600/year) on prepaid Fine Hotels + Resorts or The Hotel Collection bookings through Amex Travel when you pay with your Platinum Card.

You still get access to the Global Lounge Collection — including Centurion Lounges, Priority Pass (enrollment required), and select partner lounges — plus Delta Sky Club access when flying Delta .

CLEAR® Plus Credit

Receive up to \$209/year in CLEAR Plus credits (to help speed through airport security) when you pay with your Platinum Card — enrollment required.

Global Entry/TSA PreCheck Credit

A statement credit for Global Entry (\$100) or TSA PreCheck (\$85) application fees (every 4–4.5 years).

🚗 Mobility Credits

\$200 Uber Cash

Receive \$15/month in Uber Cash and a \$20 bonus in December to use on Uber rides or Uber Eats in the U. S. (must add your Platinum Card to your Uber account).

\$120 Uber One Credit

Up to \$120/year in statement credits if you pay for an auto-renewing Uber One membership with your Platinum Card.

🏨 Hotel & Status Perks

Fine Hotels + Resorts benefits (room upgrades when available, daily breakfast for two, early check-in/late check-out, unique property amenity) via Amex Travel bookings.

The Hotel Collection perks: \$100 hotel credit + room upgrade (when available) on 2-night minimum stays.

You can also apply for Marriott and Hilton status when you're a card holder, as well as Avis and Hertz.

These stack with the \$600 hotel credit above.

🛍️ Lifestyle & Shopping Credits

(Enrollment often required; must activate credits each year or quarter where applicable.)

\$100 Saks Fifth Avenue Credit

Up to \$100/year (split \$50 Jan–June and \$50 July–Dec) for purchases at Saks Fifth Avenue or Saks.com — no minimum purchase.

\$400 Resy Dining Credit

Up to \$100/quarter (total \$400/year) on eligible dining purchases through Resy.

\$300 Digital Entertainment Credit

Up to \$25/month (total \$300/year) for eligible digital entertainment services — now including Paramount+. YouTube

Spring 2026 Shoe Trends Are Freakier Than Ever: See Our Top 9

Andrea Bossi · Refinery29 Fashion

As fashion moves away from the clutches of “quiet luxury” and minimalist beige looks, footwear is feeling more fun than ever. In fact, shoes are in their freaky era .

“Everyone is embracing their whimsy. We’ve moved past quiet luxury, and we’re even numb to logo mania. Style right now is about self-expression, individuality, and having fun with what you wear,” designer Larissa Muehleder tells Refinery29 of what’s defining today’s shoe trends.

This spring, the coolest kicks are a spirited extension of the self, whether they’re a classic silhouette made with a non-traditional material or a retro style that’s been reborn. We’re not just talking about Tabis, traditionally Japanese footwear with a split-toe, which have been popularized by Maison Margiela. Instead, this season’s eccentric styles toy with the familiar to create something fresh, whether they came from a runway or seem more inspired by street style .

Read on for the top shoe trends that will dominate the transitional season, like high-vamp heels on the brink of a viral explosion thanks to Chanel’s revival , as well as playfully embellished styles that make florals actually feel groundbreaking for spring.

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Low-Profile Sneakers

We’re in an era of “minimalist and slim sneakers that are more so lifestyle silhouettes and not designed for working out,” according to women’s sports expert and editor Vinciane Ngomsi . Rather than the bejeweled kicks or chunky dad shoes of recent years, today’s favorite sneakers have gone back to basics, usually championing a slim, low profile that feels reminiscent of nostalgic styles.

In the same vein, ballerina sneakers — often shortened to “sneakerinas” and also made with thin soles — are having their moment amid this retro-style revival. “There’s a softness and romanticism that continues to evolve in really fresh ways with this [ballet-inspired] aesthetic, and it takes us back to the dance aerobics of the ‘80s,” Muehleder says.

DashDividers_1_500x100

Strappy sandals, with or without heels, are a reliable spring-time classic, at least when “fake spring” is over. What makes the look stand out today is how it’s been tweaked from the typically neutral-hued leather version to something more personality-forward. The coolest strappy sandals right now feature dainty straps, colorful finishes, and jewelry-inspired details. “Even with simpler outfits, people want one piece that feels like a conversation starter and right now, that piece is either the handbag or the shoe,” stylist and Vin. designer Claudia Li Johnson says. Strappy sandals are an easy way to get the job done.

DashDividers_1_500x100

High-Vamp Heels

Interestingly, a more modest-looking heel has been taking over fashion. Enter, high-vamp heels, distinct for their uppers that cover a noticeable amount of the top of the foot. These, also known as glove pumps , are no longer your grandma’s heels.

Instead, today’s versions of these vintage-inspired shoes are being made to feel fresh as designers reimagine them in funky colors and singular heel shapes. Chanel — which seems to have been on the lips of all the fashion girls when its spring collection hit shelves mid-March, designed by Creative Director Matthieu Blazy — gave the look a boost thanks to its own array of high-vamp heels .

DashDividers_1_500x100

Breathable Ballet Flats: Mesh, Jelly, & Crochet

The mesh ballet flat moment may have first exploded years ago, thanks to then-creative director Pieter Mulier’s new Alaïa design , but the look is still going strong, albeit with modifications. Breathable, sheer styles remain trendy this spring, and it’s not just about mesh anymore. Jelly and crochet, which tend to channel a more fun and colorful vibe, are now dominating.

Getting ballet flats in jelly materials can also be a lifehack for saving cash when buying designer. After all, they tend to be the cheaper option when looking for a “luxury” version of the ballet flat. For example, just look at Jimmy Choo’s jelly flat that retails for \$495 in comparison to a similar style made in leather that sells for \$950.

DashDividers_1_500x100

It’s a slingback spring . Though the heeled design of these shoes seems antithetical to comfort, these are a favorite for exactly that reason. Thanks to their mostly open foot and typically lower heel, slingbacks are a great choice for that in-between weather where you still want to walk with ease.

“As a designer, it genuinely makes me happy to see women embracing their inner child,” Muehleder, who launched her eponymous line in 2014, says. “Authenticity doesn’t have an age limit. Style comes from what ignites joy in you, not what you think is expected of you.”

There’s no one right way to wear slingbacks. Pick your color and heel height based on what feels best for your personal style. A butter yellow slingback with a kitten heel does just as well as a designer pair that’s slightly taller with bows sewn onto the sides.

DashDividers_1_500x100

Peep-Toe Mules

Heels this spring will strongly feature a flash of toe, but

'In Switzerland, it's possible to sledge between two railway stations': readers' favourite family adventures in Europe

Guardian readers · The Guardian Travel

Alpine playgrounds, unforgettable train rides and white-water rafting feature in our readers' family trips from Norway to the Netherlands

- Tell us about a trip to a UK national park or national nature reserve – the best tip wins a £200 holiday voucher

Travelling by rail in Europe gives you plenty of opportunity for ad-hoc adventure. We were returning from a ski trip in Italy and took the Bernina Express part of the way. We'd heard that if you disembark at Bergün, leave your luggage at the station and take the train back one stop to Preda village it's possible to sledge between the two stations. So there we found ourselves renting traditional wooden sledges from Preda and walking the short distance to the start of the tobogganing run. What we thought might be a gentle run into town turned into a fast and fun-filled couple of hours as we hurtled down the tree-lined course. At times it felt like we were in the game Mario Kart and at one point a children's birthday party overtook us, the birthday girl's sledge trailing balloons. About 5 miles later we arrived back in Bergün, before continuing our train journey onwards.

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So there we found ourselves renting traditional wooden sledges from Preda and walking the short distance to the start of the tobogganing run.

Guardian readers

miso chicken and rice

deb · Smitten Kitchen

How do you cook when your kitchen isn't available for kitchen-ing? On a Sunday last April, I awoke at the crack of dawn jet-lagged from an (excellent) trip to Amsterdam* to an email from my apartment building that ConEd had found a gas leak in the main line to the building and had shut down service for safety. With this, I was indoctrinated into a society of New Yorkers I previously hadn't known existed, as NYC is apparently riddled with tales of people who lived without gas for (what seemed like the minimum of) 6 months and up to 18 months while their building trudged at a snail's pace through rounds of repairs and inspections.

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‘No cars, unspoilt beaches and seabirds rule’: readers’ favourite European island escapes

Guardian readers · The Guardian Travel

From the rugged north of Scotland to the glittering Aegean, our tipsters recommend islands for slowing down, lazing around and taking in nature • Tell us about a spring activity or day out – the best tip wins a £200 holiday voucher

A short ferry ride from Vigo (daily and overnight visitor numbers are capped) took us to the tiny archipelago of the Cíes Islands , a protected cluster of islands where seabirds rule and tiny beaches remain unspoilt. There are no cars on the island and only a few small restaurants dotted about. There is one campsite, with little else but the waves of the Atlantic to lull you to sleep. I felt as if I had won the lottery when we visited and knew this would be an experience not easily matched. Helen E

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Holy parades and earthly pleasures in Spain: Easter in Granada

Kitty Corrigan · The Guardian Travel

The ancient city – with its gardens, hammams and Moorish architecture – comes alive in spring and its Holy Week processions are among the most authentic in Andalucía

As I turned the corner on a narrow, cobbled street in Granada, I felt as if I had stumbled upon a slightly sinister re-enactment society. Mysterious men dressed in white robes and tall, conical, face-covering hats with slits for their eyes were followed by women in black dresses and mantillas , holding pillar candles and crosses, then children wearing caped cloaks, carrying baskets of prayer cards.

It was indeed a re-enactment of sorts, but deeply rooted in Catholicism, representing the Passion of Christ, staged during Holy Week (Semana Santa), which runs from 29 March to 5 April this year. Easter processions are held across the country, but this Andalucían city hosts one of the most authentic in Spain.

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Walking with the weavers 200 years after the Lancashire uprising

Chris Moss · The Guardian Travel

Former mill towns in the West Pennine Moors tell the story of the workers’ rebellion against power looms, the new machines decimating their livelihoods

There’s a massive hole in the ground at the top of Whinney Hill – a shale quarry that once supplied raw materials for Accrington’s famous Nori brickworks (as used in the Empire State Building and Blackpool Tower). It’s fitting, as there’s a chasm in history when it comes to this unprepossessing spot on the edge of the West Pennine Moors.

On the morning of 24 April 1826, about 1,000 weavers met on the hilltop to plan their day and, no doubt, get the lie of the land and the weather before setting off. A banking crisis in December of the previous year – dubbed the Panic of 1825 by historians – had hammered the cotton industry. Lancashire’s weavers, who had already suffered years of declining wages and living standards, faced destitution and even starvation.

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‘Children see magic in the smallest adventures’: exploring Scotland with my four-year-old

Phoebe Smith · The Guardian Travel

On a tight budget, we stayed in a bothy, climbed a mountain, looked for Nessie and – best of all – made memories that money can’t buy

“There! There – I can see it!” The cries of my four-year-old echoed around the ruins of 13th-century Urquhart Castle , causing a group of US tourists to come running over to the corbelled bartizans (overhanging turrets) where we stood. “It’s Nessie, I saw her,” he insisted, pointing at the ripples spinning out from the back of a sightseeing vessel on Loch Ness.

This was day four of a budget, week-long Scotland adventure for the two of us, and we were spending the day in Drumnadrochit, on the shores of the country’s most famous body of water, looking for the fabled monster.

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‘The intimate and the epic’: the best way to understand India is to travel by train

Rahul Bhattacharya · The Guardian Travel

Being a passenger in this vast country is ‘a full-blooded immersion in the local’, says the novelist whose latest protagonist is lured by the romance of the rails

I carry my train journeys in my bones, the juddering song of the Indian rail. Our first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, famously likened India to a palimpsest, no layer quite effacing the one that went before. That’s how I think of Indian railway journeys. They inscribe on the mind our fellow travellers, our ways, our thousand languages, our landscapes, our climate.

I think of a rail journey I made in 1998 – that brutal summer of nuclear testing – setting out from Mumbai, in an ordinary three-tier sleeper, for Dehradun, 1,000 miles (1,600km) north. The frazzled train fell off any semblance of a schedule. The voyage grew longer, past 50 hours; hotter, past 50C. I remember the metallic burn on the window grilles; the hot, killing wind that blew through them; the sizzle of water drops splashed on the face when they hit the uncovered platforms in the heart of the country; the melt of my rubber soles. A fortnight later, having trekked to the mouth of a tributary of the Ganges, completing my expedition from the Arabian Sea to a Himalayan glacier, it was possible to look back on the rail ordeal with affection.

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The Vanity Fair Oscars Party Served Up The Best Red Carpet Looks

Victoria Montalti · Refinery29 Fashion

Oscars night brought tons of historical wins for Sinners and KPop Demon Hunters , and the celebrations didn’t end when the award show finished. Immediately after, celebrities hopped over to the annual Vanity Fair Oscars party to cheers and mingle with their fellow nominees, winners, and more industry peers.

And yes, many of them changed out of their stunning Oscars red carpet outfits into new (even more extravagant) looks for the afterparty. Winners like Michael B. Jordan and Maggie Kang showed out with their Oscar trophies and beaming smiles as the cherries on top of their looks. Scarves and capes notably graced the necks of red carpet pros like Bella Hadid and Olandria Carthen , amongst other It girls. And we especially loved seeing coordinating looks from iconic duos, like partners, siblings, and even castmates (hello, Heated Rivalry boys!).

Ahead, see the best Vanity Fair red carpet looks that wrapped up awards season on a seriously glamorous note.

Photo: Courtesy of Taylor Hill/FilmMagic/Getty Images.

Michael B. Jordan

Photo: Courtesy of Jason Armond/Los Angeles Times/Getty Images.

PinkPantheress

Photo: Courtesy of Daniele Venturelli/WireImage/Getty Images.

Jeff Goldblum and Emilie Livingston

Photo: Courtesy of Daniele Venturelli/WireImage/Getty Images.

Photo: Courtesy of Doug Peters/PA Images/Getty Images.

Photo: Courtesy of Karwai Tang/WireImage/Getty Images.

Timothée Chalamet and Kylie Jenner

Photo: Courtesy of Taylor Hill/FilmMagic/Getty Images.

Photo: Courtesy of Christopher Polk/Variety/Getty Images.

Photo: Courtesy of Christopher Polk/Variety/Getty Images.

Photo: Courtesy of Doug Peters/PA Images/Getty Images.

Connor Storie and Hudson Williams

Photo: Courtesy of Karwai Tang/WireImage/Getty Images.

Photo: Courtesy of Neilson Barnard/Getty Images.

Elle Fanning and Dakota Fanning

Photo: Courtesy of Amy Sussman/Getty Images.

Photo: Courtesy of Doug Peters/PA Images/Getty Images.

Photo: Courtesy of Taylor Hill/FilmMagic/Getty Images.

New sleeper service will run from Paris to Berlin next year

Monisha Rajesh · The Guardian Travel

European Sleeper will operate the new service from March 2026, replacing the Nightjet train that is being axed next month

The resurgence of sleeper trains on the continent hit a kink in the tracks in September, when the Austrian state operator ÖBB announced that it would be axing its two Nightjet services – Paris to Vienna and Paris to Berlin – from 14 December. ÖBB cited the French government's ending of subsidies, dealing a blow to the night-train renaissance.

However, there is light at the end of the tunnel. European Sleeper has told the Guardian that it will be taking over the route from Paris to Berlin, with the first train to run on 26 March 2026. The train will operate three times a week with departures likely to be from Paris Gare du Nord on Tuesday, Thursday and Sunday evenings and the return service from Berlin Hauptbahnhof and Ostbahnhof on Monday, Wednesday and Friday. The current Nightjet service departs Paris Gare de l'Est just after 7pm and winds east via Strasbourg, Frankfurt, Erfurt and Halle before arriving in Berlin around 8.30am. European Sleeper intends to make the journey via Brussels, with precise route details and timings currently being confirmed with infrastructure managers in France, Belgium and Germany.

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banana chocolate chip cake

deb · Smitten Kitchen

Somehow, despite how impossible it seems (to me, a person who has neither aged nor matured a day), it's been almost twenty years since I first told you about my family's favorite coffee cake. It's tall, plush, crisp with a flaky layer of cinnamon sugar on top, studded with a quilt of chocolate chips and is downright, well, adorable when cut into cubes because they're a little wobbly. When one tumbles, it shakes off a little pfft of cinnamon sugar, like a pup coming in from today's blizzard. It's perfect. It needs no changes or updates.

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IN BRIEF

Jules Yap, IKEA Hackers: A new IKEA study has confirmed what many of us have suspected while staring into cluttered cabinets: our kitchens just aren't working for us. The good news? You don't need a full renovation to turn things around. According to the IKEA Cooking & Eating Report 2026, one of the largest studies of its kind, surveying over 31,000 people across 31 countries, fewer than one in three of us are actually happy with our kitchens. And the number one culprit? Space. [...]

Adrianna Adarme, A Cozy Kitchen: This Miso Lemon Salmon is quick, easy, and comes together in under 20 minutes. It's the perfect weeknight meal that...

(Read more...)

Tags: 30 Minute Meal Dinner Healthy lunch Quick and Easy

The post Easy Miso Lemon Salmon appeared first on A Cozy Kitchen .

Nicole Samoroukova, The Reformed Broker (Josh Brown): On episode 118 of The Compound and Friends, Michael Batnick and Downtown Josh Brown are joined by Kevin Simpson to discuss: covered call strategies, the Fed, Warren Buffett's latest moves, and much more! You can listen to the whole thing below, or find it wherever you like to listen to your favorite pods!

Listen here: Apple podcasts Spotify podcasts Google podcasts Everywhere else! Follow Michael's blog at [📍](#)...

The post The Fed's Gonna Cut appeared first on The Reformed Broker .

Jules Yap, IKEA Hackers: The GREJIG wire shoe rack was always just ... there. Doing its job quietly. Now IKEA has built a whole system around it. The IKEA GREJIG shoe rack has never been a headline product. It's a single-tier wire rack that holds your shoes and costs \$4.99. It works. It doesn't ask for much. Most people who own one barely remember buying it. Which makes what IKEA has just done with the range all the more interesting. GREJIG is now a [...]

Nicole Samoroukova, The Reformed Broker (Josh Brown): OK, we're trying something new next week for registered financial advisors only. It's a brand new show we've created and you can be there virtually to watch the pilot episode live. As an advisor, you're going to spend time, money and energy implementing new technology and asset management solutions into your practice. You may as well get good at it. register for The Smoke Show live pilot episode h...

The post The Smoke Show appeared first on The Reformed Broker .

Gina Homolka, Skinnytaste: My homemade Greek salad dressing recipe is simple, fresh, and brightly tangy, but I add an optional secret ingredient that makes it next-level delicious. Scale it up for a party, or scale it down to make a salad for one! Homemade Greek Dressing Recipe There's absolutely no reason to buy Greek salad dressing at the [...]

Lale Arikoglu, Condé Nast Traveler: For her latest season with CNN, actor Eva Longoria pursues a passion for French cooking. Lale Arikoglu joins her on set in Burgundy.

Joshua M Brown, The Reformed Broker (Josh Brown): Ladies and gentlemen, this is the final post I will be publishing at The Reformed Broker. After today the site will be inactive, forever. I began this blog in November 2008 without any idea where it would take me. I had a negative net worth, was working at a dead-end brokerage firm job and absolutely no career prospects whatsoever – a washed up stock broker at 31 years old in the middle of a global financial crisis....

The post This is the end appeared first on The Reformed Broker .

Gina Homolka, Skinnytaste: Bell Pepper and Potato Frittata. Egg frittatas are my answer to an easy, inexpensive meal solution whether I'm having it for breakfast, lunch or dinner. I served these with a side of berries or fruit. For dinner, I serve with a salad on the side and call it a meal! Four-Leaf Clover Frittata This Bell [...]

deb, Smitten Kitchen:

Although spinach gnudi — soft, pillowy cheese dumplings fried in browned butter and sage — are traditionally more of a spring or summer food, I'm here to make the argument we should eat them right now, in prime soup-and-sweater weather. Because did you hear the part about warm cheese? the puddle of brown butter? the earthy sage? It's a symphony of delicious fall things and if you tell me you don't want to curl up on the plate and take a nap in it, fine, I'll believe you but I do think you're in denial.

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Adrianna Adarme, A Cozy Kitchen: This Steak Salad with Creamy Chimichurri Dressing is crisp, herby, and satisfying without feeling heavy. Quick-seared steak, tender greens, and...

(Read more...)

Tags: Chimichurri Dinner Dinner for Two Healthy lunch no-toc Salad Steak

The post Steak Salad with Creamy Chimichurri Dressing appeared first on A Cozy Kitchen .

Gina Homolka, Skinnytaste: This lighter, make-ahead overnight baked French toast casserole with Bananas Foster is guaranteed to impress—perfect for Easter morning or any special brunch! Bananas Foster French Toast The challah bread in this French toast casserole absorbs the eggy custard, flavored with vanilla and cinnamon, overnight. The next morning, while it bakes in the oven, you'll whip [...]

Gina Homolka, Skinnytaste: Roasted Carrot Hummus is a creamy dip made with sweet roasted carrots, chickpeas, tahini, garlic, and lemon. It's a bright, flavorful appetizer perfect for spring gatherings and Easter. Roasted Carrot Hummus My friend made this Roasted Carrot Hummus and was so excited for me to try it that I had to recreate it at home. [...]

Adrianna Adarme, A Cozy Kitchen: This Steak Salad with Creamy Chimichurri Dressing is crisp, herby, and satisfying without feeling heavy. Quick-seared steak, tender greens, and...

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